



PORTFOLIO CASE STUDY

BioShock: What Players Value

A data-driven analysis of the trilogy's reception,
and how it can shape the revival

Savion Barron | September 2026

github.com/saviongb/Bioshock-Revival-Analysis



Executive Summary

SITUATION

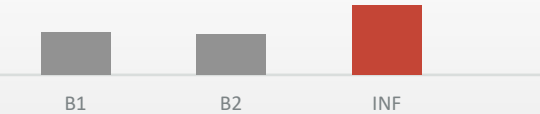
Thirteen years after Infinite, BioShock’s next release can draw on 85,395 player reviews across the franchise to guide development direction

WHAT THE REVIEWS SHOW

Narrative is the heart of BioShock

24.6 / 23.5 / 40.4

% of reviews mentioning narrative

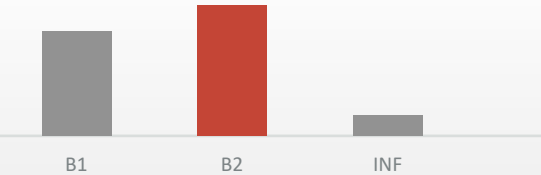


Reviewers recognize storytelling elements across the franchise. Narrative is the only theme mentioned in at least 20% of reviews for each title

Technical performance dominates negative reviews

60.5 / 75.3 / 12.0

% of negative reviews mentioning technical

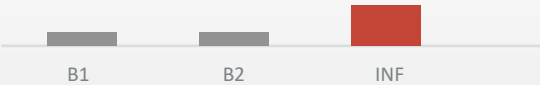


Negative reviews of the B1 and B2 mentioned technical performance at significantly higher rates than infinite

Infinite leaned into narrative, away from combat

8.0 / 7.9 / 23.6

% of negative reviews mentioning combat



Nearly ¼ of the negative reviews of Infinite mentioned combat elements with pacing following a similar trend

RECOMMENDATION

The next BioShock should protect its narrative driven identity while not losing sight of what differentiates it from other titles, an engaging combat system. Additionally, delivering a polished product will be key for launch success.

State of the next BioShock

WHAT IS KNOWN

- 1 2K announced Cloud Chamber in 2019, the studio that will develop the next BioShock. Q3 FY2020 materials noted that the next installment would be in development for several years
- 2 Leadership change and reset. Take-Two Q2 FY2026 earnings call confirmed Rod Fergusson as head of BioShock franchise and now leading Cloud Chamber. Slatoff (2K President) on record stating that “the next BioShock is going to take the franchise to the next level”.
- 3 CEO commented on the difficulty of development. Zelnick expresses his disappointment with the wait, explaining that resources were committed to creative directions that led nowhere.

QUESTIONS THAT IMPACT DEVELOPMENT

- 1 What elements of past BioShock titles should 2K protect/retain?
- 2 Where was negative reception of the franchise directed?
- 3 Has the 13-year dormancy changed perception or interest in the franchise?

Method and instrument

85,395

English reviews across BioShock 1 Remastered, BioShock 2 Remastered and Infinite from Steam's public API with python

▶ **9**

Theme dictionaries ran against all reviews in pandas to identify which themes are mentioned (e.g. see appendix for full dictionaries).

▶ **4**

measures per theme: frequency, verdict split, review era, playtime groups

▶ **72**

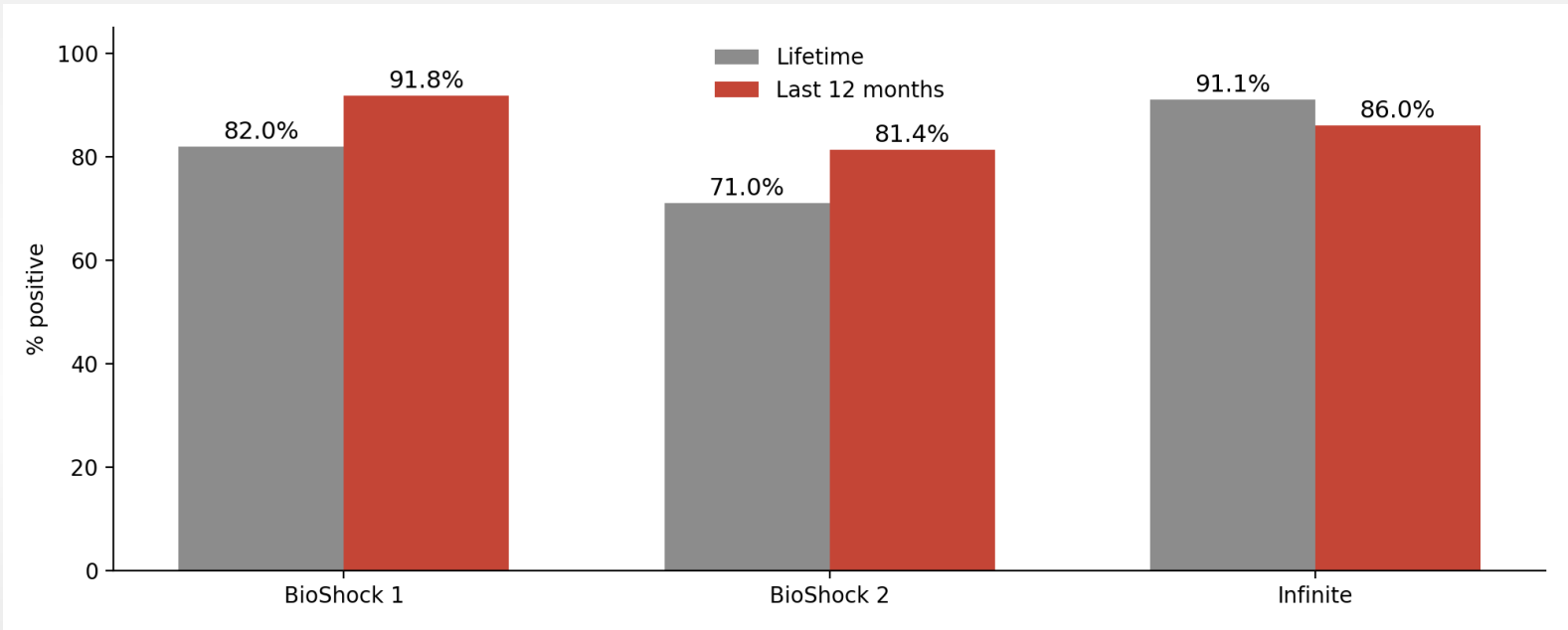
reviews hand-coded to measure precision and recall for every theme

Registered first

Full impressions and hypothesis were written after all three BioShock playthroughs were completed then committed to github before data analysis. Theme dictionaries were also committed before any analysis to reduce curve fitting.

<https://github.com/saviongb/Bioshock-Revival-Analysis>

A decade later, the remasters review better than their lifetime average



REVIEWS IN THE LAST 12 MONTHS

2,346

BioShock Remastered

1,290

BioShock 2 Remastered

1,577

Infinite

After nearly 2 decades since the original release of BioShock 1 and a decade after the remasters, reviewers still respond positively to the BioShock blueprint.

Base: % positive within each group, lifetime and the 12 months to July 26, 2026.

Narrative is the only theme mentioned in at least 20% of reviews across all BioShock titles

BioShock 1

24.6%

2nd highest % across 9 tested

BioShock 2

23.5%

2nd highest % across 9 tested

Infinite

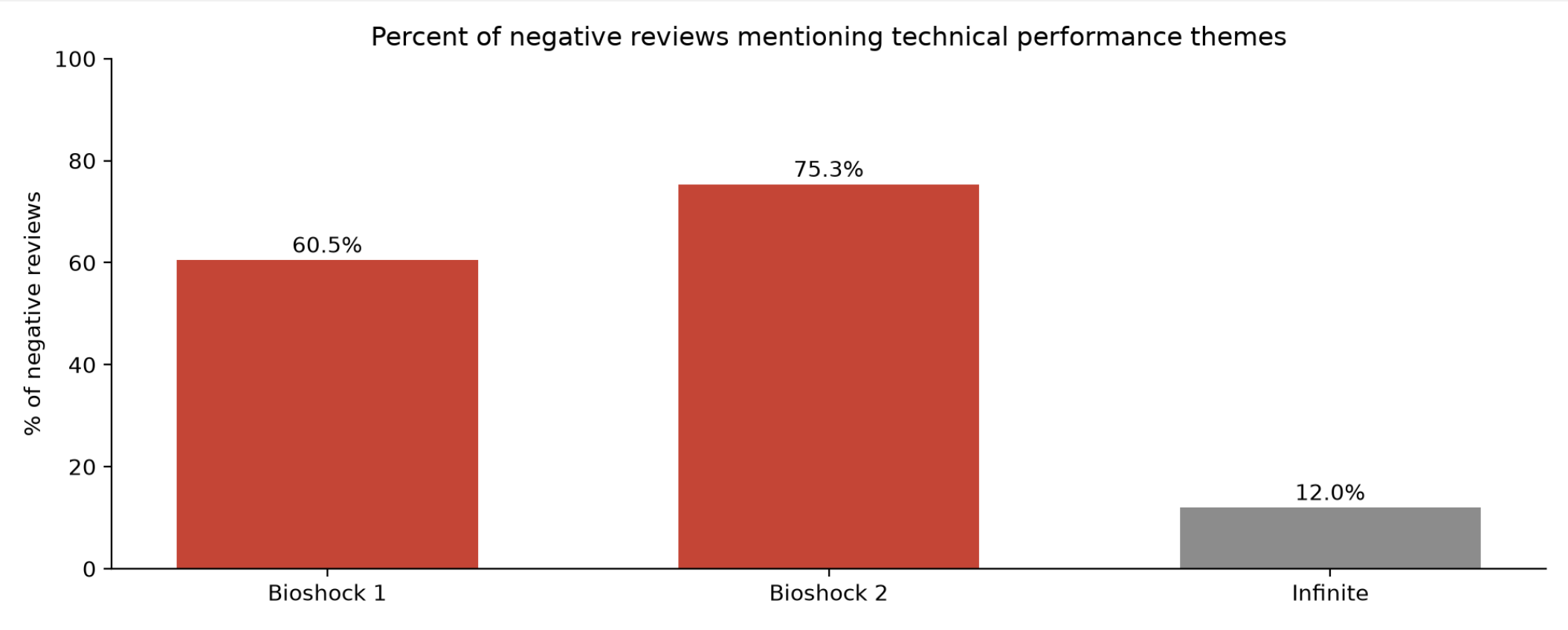
40.4%

Highest % across 9 tested

Technical performance is mentioned in a higher % of reviews for BioShock 1 (25.0%) and BioShock 2 (40.3%), although reflects the port rather than game design.

Base: % of each title’s reviews mentioning narrative (B1: 26,155) (B2: 12,008) (Infinite: 47,232)

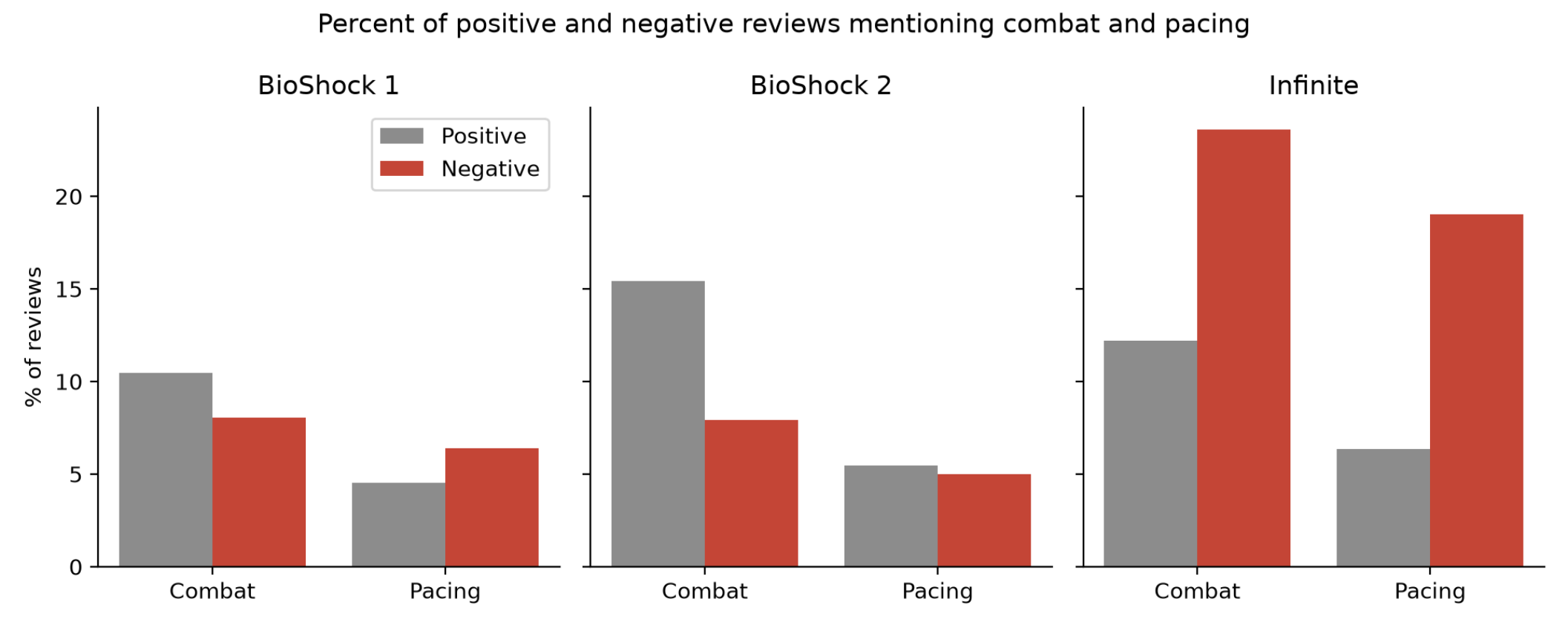
BioShock 1 & 2 reviews mention technical performance in negative reviews at a higher rate than Infinite



Base: % of each game’s negative reviews (B1 4,698, B2 3,480, Infinite 4,182)

Technical detection recall was 58%, true mention rates likely higher than shown

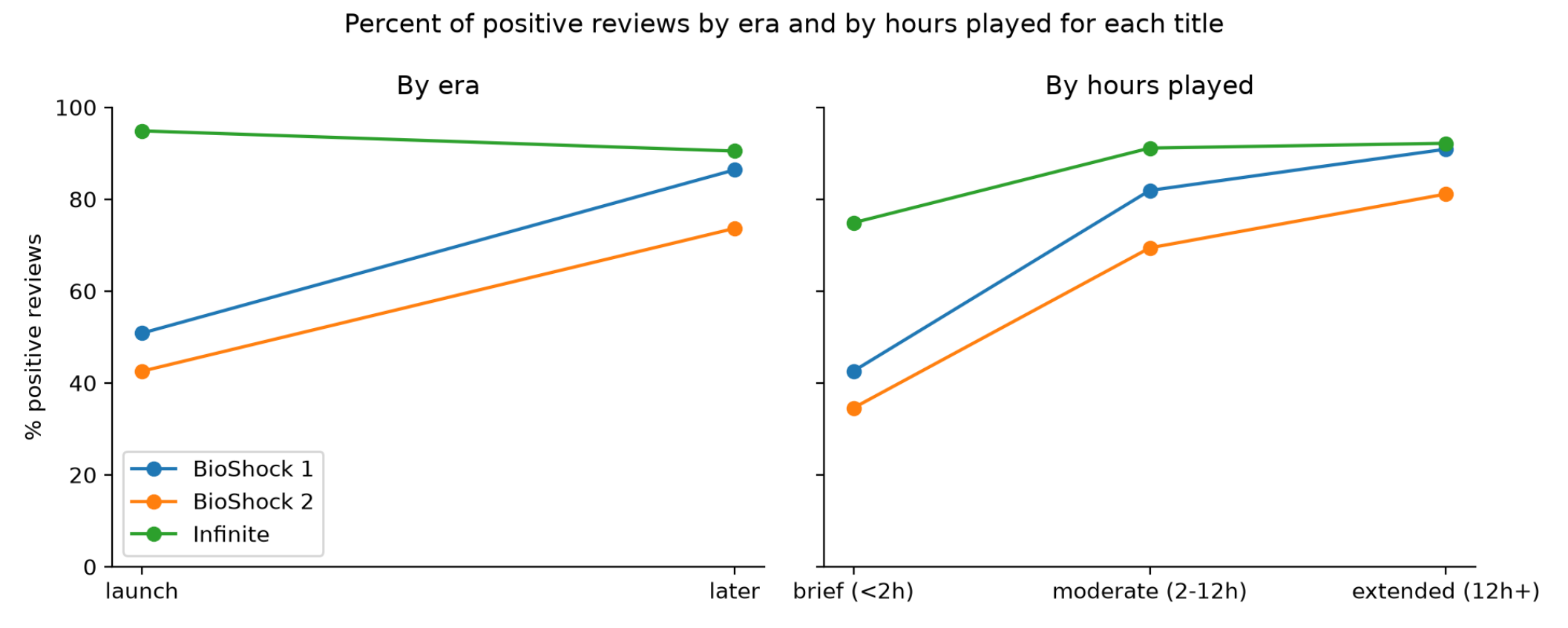
Combat and pacing mentioned in a higher percent of Infinite's negative reviews compared to remasters



Base: % of each game's positive reviews and % of its negative reviews (B1 21,457 / 4,698) (B2 8,528 / 3,480) (Infinite 43,050 / 4,182)

Combat and pacing detection was weak (recall 57% and 40%)

Positive reviews skew higher in later eras and as playtime increased, except in Infinite's later era decline



Base: % of each game's positive reviews within each era and playtime group (n varies)

Era and playtime groups represent different reviewers, not how individual perception changes over time

Hypothesis results

Prediction	Evidence	Result
BioShock's positive reviews emphasize narrative and atmosphere	Narrative: + 27.6% / - 10.6% Atmosphere: + 5.6% / - 1.9%	Partially confirmed
BioShock's negative reviews emphasize pacing and combat	Pacing: + 4.5% / - 6.4% Combat: + 10.5% / - 8%	Not confirmed
BioShock 2's positive reviews will emphasize combat mechanics	Combat: + 15.4% / - 7.9%	Partially confirmed
BioShock 2's negative reviews will emphasize storytelling elements and technical stability	Narrative: +28.3% / - 11.9% Technical: + 26% / - 75.3%	Partially confirmed
Infinities positive reviews will emphasize storytelling elements	Narrative: + 40.6% / - 38.4% negative	Partially confirmed
Infinities negative reviews will emphasize mechanical aspects	Combat: + 12.2% / - 23.6% negative	Confirmed

Predictions were committed before data was examined and any theme dictionaries were set

What the findings suggest for the next BioShock

01

Narrative is the essence of BioShock

Players recognize and discuss the rich narrative that has become the centerpiece of BioShock's identity. These elements should be protected in BioShock 4 development

02

Stability can overshadow design

Technical performance can negatively influence a player's perception and overshadow appreciation for design. Prioritize technical performance and functionality testing in BioShock 4

03

Infinite changed course on Combat

Infinite was right to prioritize narrative, although players discussed the combat more often in negative reviews than previous titles. The next BioShock should address this imbalance and innovate upon the combat style players appreciated

Takeaway

BioShock 4 must strike a balance between aspects it has proven it can deliver

BioShock 4 should continue to protect its ambitious narrative driven identity while not losing sight of what makes the series immersive (combat). Delivering a polished product will be key to its initial success.

DOOM (2016) – When the revival goes right

12 years



13 years



95%

DOOM (2016) reviews positive

84,839

English steam reviews

The 2016 DOOM release serves as an example of the success that can follow from reviving an acclaimed title/series

Base: DOOM (2016) data from steam store summary, accessed [9/3/2026]. Figures only intended to provide an example of a successful revival.

Dishonored 2 (2016) – Acclaim alone cannot carry a sequel

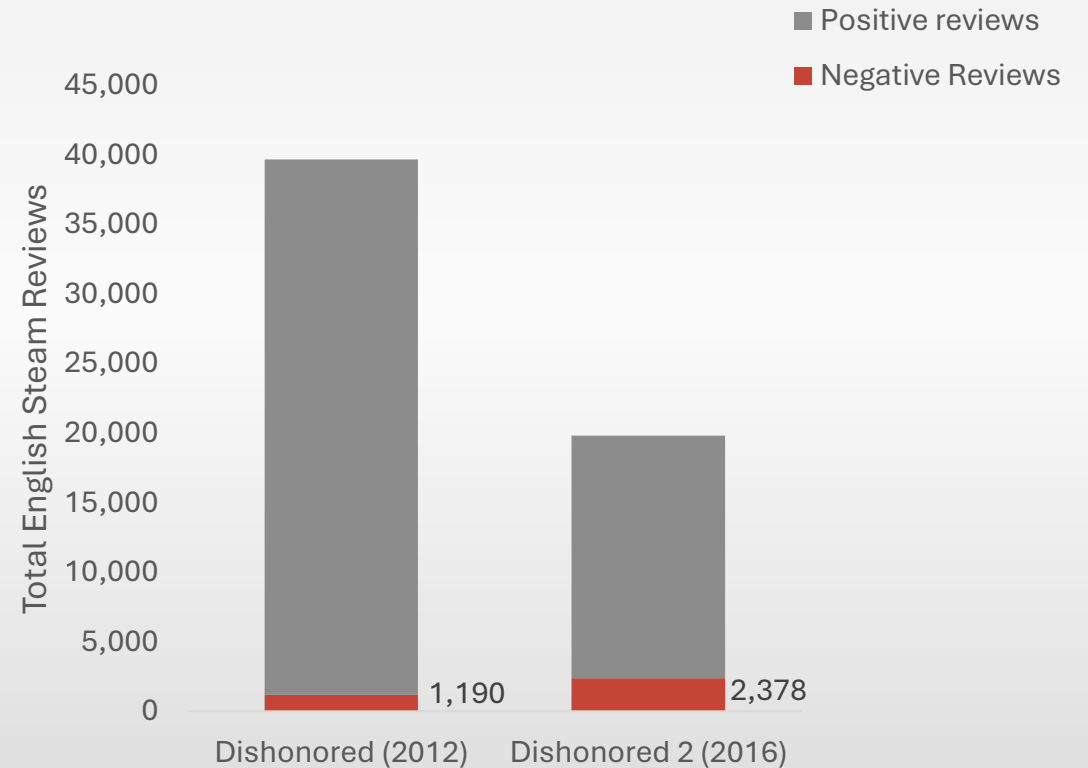
Even with the most beloved titles, a sequel cannot ride on acclaim alone. Dishonored 2 has roughly twice as many negative English steam reviews with half the total reviews.

97%

Dishonored (2012)

88%

Dishonored 2 (2016)



Base: Dishonored (2012) and Dishonored 2 (2016) data from steam store summary, accessed [9/3/2026]. Figures only intended to provide an example of a less successful revival.

What this analysis cannot tell you

Attention, not approval

The analysis used keyword identification to count specific themes across positive and negative reviews. This tells us what reviewers talk about, not their approval/disapproval.

Remasters, English, Steam

BioShock 1 and 2 are remastered releases, Infinite is original. All data is sourced from English Steam reviews only

Every theme undercounts

Validation recall ranged from 93% for narrative to 25% for visual and audio. Comparing the same theme across each title is consistent, although cross-theme comparisons are inaccurate.

No causal claims

The analysis best suited for understanding what BioShock reviewers discuss, rather than making concrete decisions on design.

Appendix - Theme dictionaries

Theme	Keywords
Narrative	twist, would you kindly, betrayal, obedience, protector, flashback, redemption, timeline, multiverse, realities, constants, genes, genetic engineering, gene altering, autonomy, agency, conditioned, kidnapping, storytelling, narrative, writing, dialogue, story, plot, ending
Setting	rapture, underwater, city, art deco, retro, theatre, columbia, floating, sky, americana, steampunk, utopia, environment, architecture, dystopian, ocean, ruins, aesthetic, lighthouse, pavilion, arcadia, prometheus, amusements
Atmosphere	horror, eerie, scary, tense, immersive, uncomfortable, disturbing, mystery, dread, claustrophobic, twisted, unsettling
Characters	jack, ryan, atlas, fontaine, tenenbaum, cohen, little sister, daddies, daddy, splicer, delta, eleanor, lamb, sofia, sinclair, grace, big sister, poole, booker, elizabeth, comstock, songbird, twins, daisy, turrets, mosquito, zeppelin, barrage, handyman, fireman, zealot, motorized patriot, siren, boy of silence, lutece, suchong
Combat	plasmids, combat, movement, quantum tear, weapons, gunplay, shooting, vigors, guns, wrench, research camera, drill, rivet, hack, sky-hook, adam, eve, tonics, difficulty
Ideology	capitalism, greed, individualism, free will, wealth disparity, exploitation, slavery, selfishness, political, religious, religion, oppression, collectivism, utilitarianism, exceptionalism, communism, police state, ayn rand, authoritarian, right wing, morality, objectivism, racism, nationalism
Visual/Audio	lighting, audio, graphics, music, voice acting, sound design, style, soundtrack
Technical	crash, stutter, performance, port, patch, fov, mouse, bugs, optimization, fps, controls, resolution, freezing, freeze, glitching, glitch, glitches, crashes, crashed, crashing, laggy
Pacing	repetitive, short, long, boring, tedious, replay ability, backtrack, drags, filler, padding

Appendix - Validation Results

Theme	Precision	Recall
Narrative	0.87	0.93
Setting	.80	.50
Atmosphere	1.0	0.30
Characters	.8	.67
Combat	1.0	.57
Ideology	.50	.50
Visual/audio	.75	.25
Technical	.91	.58
Pacing	.50	.40

Appendix – data and comparison sources

Game	English Steam Reviews	% positive	Source	Accessed
BioShock Remastered	26,155	82.0	Steam review API (notebook 1)	July 26, 2026
BioShock 2	12,008	71.0	Steam review API (notebook 1)	July 26, 2026
BioShock Infinite	47,232	91.1	Steam review API (notebook 1)	July 26, 2026
Doom (2016)	84,839	95.0	Steam store review summary	September 3, 2026
Dishonored (2012)	39,664	97.0	Steam store review summary	September 3, 2026
Dishonored 2 (2016)	19,817	88.0	Steam store review summary	September 3, 2026

Appendix - repository, sources, and AI use

REPOSITORY

github.com/saviongb/Bioshock-Revival-Analysis
Impressions, Notebooks, Theme dictionaries, Predictions, and Commit history.

AI USE

Claude was used as a programming guide and brainstorming tool, all analytical decisions, hand-coding, and findings are my own.

SOURCES CITED

Take-Two Q3 FY2020 earnings

Feb 6, 2020 — ir.take2games.com/node/26586/pdf

Take-Two Q2 FY2026 earnings call

Nov 6, 2025 — <https://www.roic.ai/quote/TTWO:UW/transcripts/2026-year/2-quarter>

Take-Two Q1 FY2027 results

Aug 7, 2026 — <https://www.take2games.com/ir>

Game File, Stephen Totilo

May 2026 — <https://www.gamefile.news/p/bioshock-gta-nfl-civ7-take-two-strauss-zelnick>

Appendix - scope and definitions

CORPUS

85,395 English reviews pulled from Steam's public review API on July 26, 2026. BioShock Remastered 26,155, BioShock 2 Remastered 12,008, BioShock Infinite 47,232.

TITLES

BioShock 1 and 2 are the 2016 remastered releases, not the original 2007 and 2010 versions. Infinite is the original release.

VERDICT

Positive or negative as recorded by Steam's thumbs up / thumbs down, not from review text.

REVIEW ERA

Launch era covers the first 12 months after each title's Steam release; later era covers everything after. Era groups are different reviewers, not the same reviewers over time.

PLAYTIME BANDS

Brief under 2 hours, moderate 2 to 12 hours, extended 12 hours or more, hours recorded at the time of review.

RECENT DATA (SLIDE 4)

Reviews written in the 12 months to July 26, 2026. While still a finding, not a major component of the review data analysis. Intended to provide an idea of how players respond to the title currently.